

YOU BELIEVE THE RIGHT THINGS



"That is not flattery, I mean it as a description."

"If I asked you tonight whether there is one God, you would say yes, and you would be correct, and you would not have to think about it."

"A question your correctness cannot answer."

not whether it is **true**. whether it is **alive**.

→ *that word goes in the empty box, and not before you say it*

no way to answer it by checking doctrine · in this case the doctrine is perfect

THE TEXT

14 What good is it, my brothers and sisters, if someone claims to have faith but has no deeds? Can such faith save them? **15** Suppose a brother or a sister is without clothes and daily food. **16** If one of you says to them, "Go in peace; keep warm and well fed," but does nothing about their physical needs, what good is it? **17** In the same way, faith by itself, if it is not accompanied by action, is dead. **18** But someone will say, "You have faith; I have deeds." Show me your faith without deeds, and I will show you my faith by my deeds. **19** You believe that there is one God. Good! Even the demons believe that, and shudder.

PAN DOWN HERE

20 You foolish person, do you want evidence that faith without deeds is useless? **21** Was not our father Abraham considered righteous for what he did when he offered his son Isaac on the altar? **22** You see that his faith and his actions were working together, and his faith was made complete by what he did. **23** And the scripture was fulfilled that says, "Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness," and he was called God's friend. **24** You see that a person is considered righteous by what they do and not by faith alone. **25** In the same way, was not even Rahab the prostitute considered righteous for what she did when she gave lodging to the spies and sent them off in a different direction? **26** As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is dead.

Nothing is highlighted on this page on purpose. It is read flat and whole, and verse 19 has to arrive cold on page 4.

"Now the problem, and I am not going to soften it."

THE COLLISION

JAMES 2:24

"a person is considered righteous by what they do and **not by faith alone**"

PAUL · ROMANS 3:28

"a person is justified **by faith apart from** the works of the law"

→ those two phrases go into the two slots, slow, one at a time. then draw the collision between them.

same words

same **Abraham**

same verse · **Gen 15:6**

JAMES · HIS VERDICT

↔

PAUL · HIS VERDICT

Luther. Called James an *epistle of straw*. Placed it among the disputed books at the end of his New Testament, and argued that its use of Abraham against Paul damaged its claim to apostolic authority.

"Those are not two shades of emphasis."

"They use the same words to say opposite things, and they both reach for Abraham to prove it."

"This is not a manufactured problem invented by people looking for trouble. It split the church."

"If your answer is that the tension is only apparent and we should all calm down, you have not felt the problem yet."

WHICH FAITH IS HE KILLING?

2:19 "You believe that there is one God. **Good!** Even the demons believe that, and **shudder**."

→ *the whole hinge is the gap between those two highlights. land on the second one and stop.*

the **Shema** · Deut 6:4 · said twice a day · bedrock of the whole religion
the single most correct sentence a human being can say. and he hands it to demons.



"Almost nobody reads verse 24 in the light of verse 19."

"Sit on what he just did. He reaches for the best creed available to a Jew."

"Their theology is exact. It is better than yours, because they are not guessing."

"Not two claims about one thing. Two interior acts that share an English word."

"Whatever else Paul means by faith, he does not mean a proposition sitting alone in the mind. His faith has a direction. It expresses itself through love."

2:24 · "FAITH ALONE"

= the faith of **2:19**. assent. signing the proposition.

PAUL · GAL 5:6

"faith expressing itself through love" · not bare assent

WRITE THE REFRAIN HERE

1 OF 3

ARE THESE THE SAME WORKS?

JAMES · WHAT HE COUNTS AS A WORK

MERCY TOWARD VULNERABLE BODIES

- 2:16 clothe the naked, feed the hungry
- 2:25 Rahab hides the spies, sends them out safe
- 1:27 orphans and widows in their distress

COSTLY OBEDIENCE TO GOD

- 2:21 Abraham on the mountain, the knife raised
- every one is *something a body did*, not a verbal claim

PAUL · THE WORKS HE IS FIGHTING ABOUT

- circumcision
 - food laws
 - sabbath
 - calendar
- every one a *boundary marker*, Jew from Gentile

"Watch what James counts as a work. Every single time he gives an example."

"Not one of them is a verbal claim. Every one is something a body did."

"So this is not merely philanthropy. It is claimed trust becoming bodily action."

"Different questions, different objects, same English word twice over."

→ two different objects wearing one English word. draw the gap between the questions below, and do not close it.

PAUL IS ASKING

what makes a Gentile
a member of the people of God?

SAME WORD?

JAMES IS ASKING

is the faith you claim
alive?

Keep honest. Do not say Paul's "works" are *only* ceremonial boundary markers. That is one reading and it is contested. Say the contrast is contextual: Paul rejects law-performance as the ground of righteousness, James rejects assent that never becomes obedience.

THE PATRIARCH AND THE PROSTITUTE

If James judged by the face, this pairing is insane.

ABRAHAM · 2:21

the founding insider

patriarch, father of the nation

the most respectable name a Jew can say

RAHAB · 2:25

the total outsider

foreign · a woman · a Canaanite · a prostitute

no lineage, no standing, no patron, **no ring**

THE VERDICT JAMES GIVES HIM

THE VERDICT JAMES GIVES HER

→ same words into both slots, same size. the second one slower.

both **"considered righteous for what they did"** · same verdict, same breath
 nothing comparable in inherited standing · yet James gives them the same verdict
 back to **2:1**: he refuses to receive the face *while choosing his own witnesses*

"In the language of last episode, a person with no face the world would receive."

"He sets them side by side and prices them identically."

"Whatever James is testing, it is not ancestry, respectability or social value."

"It is something that can appear identically in a patriarch and in a prostitute."

"Notice what he is doing inside his own proof."

ONE VERSE, TWO DAYS

Gen 15:6 "Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness"

quoted by both men · Rom 4:3 · Jas 2:23

DECADES LATER

15

the stars. he trusts the promise. before Isaac, before circumcision. righteousness credited.

22

the mountain. the knife. that same trust becomes costly obedience.

HOW MANY LIVES?

PAUL READS IT WHERE IT SITS

Rom 4 · the whole point is the timing
the credit came first, on nothing but trust

JAMES READS IT FORWARD

2:22-23 "made complete" · "was fulfilled"
not a second verdict. the sentence written at Gen 15 came true at Gen 22.

→ *those are the two verbs. a transaction cannot be fulfilled, so Gen 15:6 was pointing forward all along.*

Paul freezes the frame

James runs the tape

"They are quoting it about two different days."

"And listen to his verbs."

"The faith that was real in Genesis 15 is the faith that walked up the hill in Genesis 22."

"One life, filmed at two moments, by two men who each needed a different frame."

THE HAND STOPS

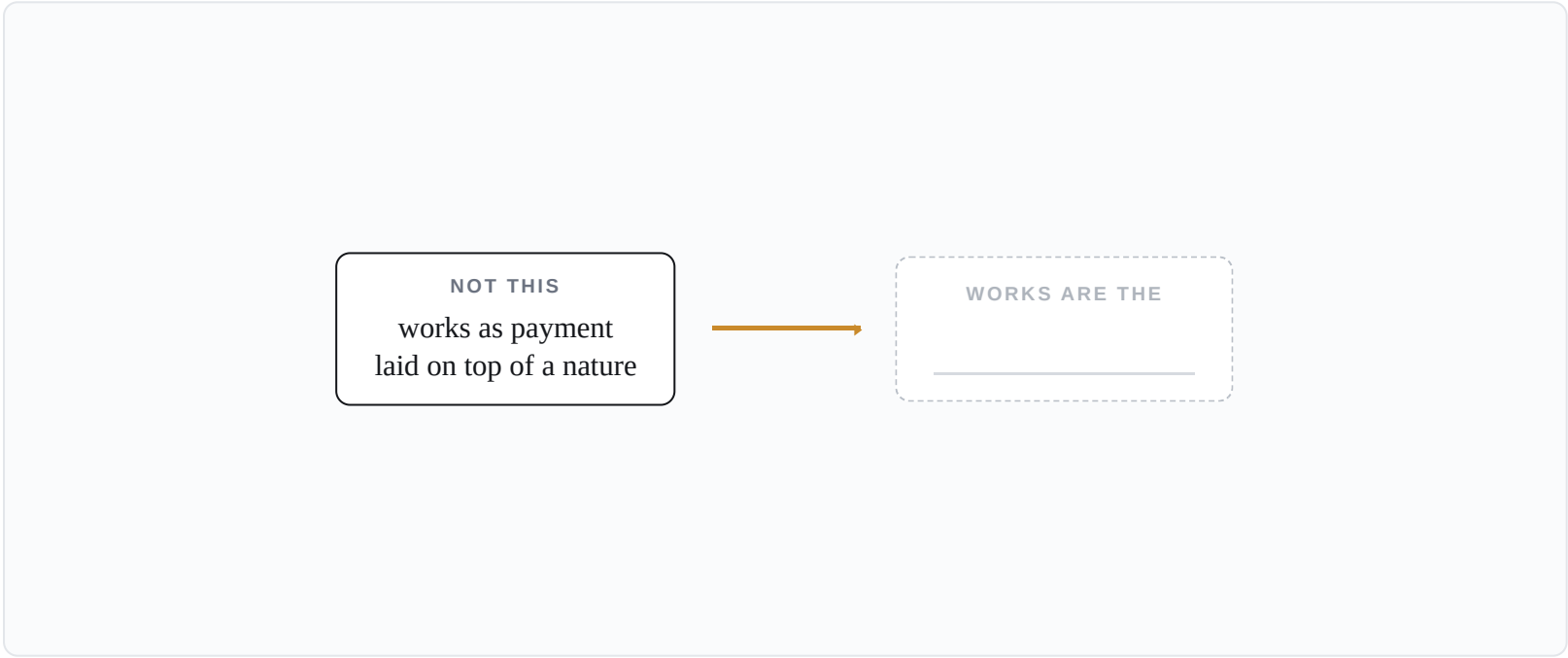
2:26 "As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is **dead**."

nekra a corpse. not weak, not immature, not incomplete.

a corpse has every feature of the living thing in the right place, and is its opposite

1:18 "he chose to give us birth through the word of truth" · *chose*, and *birth*

a new birth makes a new nature, and a nature moves. living faith does not stay motionless by nature.



the concrete instrument this chapter puts in your hand · **does anything in you move toward the person with nothing?**

→ ask it, then immediately give the qualifier. do not leave the question hanging over someone it will injure.

"James is not comparing weak faith with strong faith. He is comparing a living thing with a corpse."

"The distinction is not degree. It is life and death."

"You cannot detect the demon's faith by checking your beliefs. That is the whole horror of verse 19."

"Finding your creed correct will tell you nothing, because correctness is exactly what the dead version has."

"Here is what I want to leave on you, because it is the thing that has bothered me all week."

"And if that question is torturing you, you are not the person James is writing to, and I mean that medically as well as pastorally. He is writing to people who are comfortable."

"That is not a comfortable place to end and I am not going to pretend otherwise."